

chronisation tool was considered not ready for prime-time and might make it to our Desktops sometime in the near future.

Windows Vista underwent a thorough beta testing phase—it was tested and evaluated by the largest group of beta testers MS has ever shared their OS with till date. Come November 2006, the OS was considered ready for manufacturing. December 2006 saw the release of the business edition of Vista, while the consumer release took place on 30 January 2007.

Microsoft Vista is an operating system long overdue: not just from the perspective of the operating system's own tumultuous release cycle, but from an industry point of view as well. Technology has marched to the steady, relentless beat of progress, while the Windows OS has been caught lingering in the past—dragged down by its own history and success. In many ways, Vista could not be a revolutionary OS thanks to the gargantuan install base it might potentially alienate (or worse, leave open to competition). So what we have here is a compromise—a system that cleans up all that it can, while still retaining the Windows DNA; and most importantly, an OS that lays down the foundation for future development in the Windows ecosystem.

In the chapters to come, we will explore these ramifications in some detail, starting with the aspect of Vista that most seem to be unable to look beyond—its visual interface.

2.2 Redoing The plumbing

Microsoft has been monopolising the operating system space for a good while now. With such domination comes historical baggage. It is very difficult to exhaustively change the innards of the operating system without forcing incompatibility on to the very same customers that curse your name at every Blue Screen of Death. Then there is the little detail of resting on your laurels...